COVER STORY

The New Creator Economy

A RISING WAVE OF DIGITAL STORYTELLERS AND INFLUENCERS ARE TURNING PASSION INTO PROFIT ACROSS ONLINE INDIA

By **Suhani Singh** | *Photo-montage by* **Mandar Deodhar**

"**I never saw the world beyond my home.** I never wished to because I was content with what I had. But, one day, my son said, 'Ma, you cook so well, why don't you share it with the world?' I was shy, afraid of facing the camera, afraid to speak. But, slowly, social media taught me to be seen, to be heard, to be loved." Fifty-one-year-old Usha Bishayee, better known by her digital moniker @oldays_kitchen, won 430,000 hearts and 4.7 million views with this reel, in which she describes her first trip outside West Bengal, the first flight she took to Mumbai, where she'd eventually meet, and dance, alongside Instagram head Adam Mosseri.

Usha is one of India's 4.6 million creators aka influencers for whom video-sharing platforms like YouTube and Instagram have been life-altering. Viewers couldn't get enough of Usha's scrumptious Bengali recipes and soon brand collaborations started streaming in. Today, Usha quotes the price of an iPhone 16—a neat Rs 75,000—to big brands. Son Suprabha handles daily operations, and the duo is looking to hire a manager given the explosion in Usha's fandom.

The rise of creators like Usha is evidence of how Indians are warming up to individuals who want to show their authentic selves, often from the comfort of their homes. It helps that we are second only to Brazilians and Indonesians



Crafting Her Own Universe